Appendicitis

It is the inflammation of the vermiform appendix, leading to severe abdominal pain. The treatment involves the removal of appendix by surgery. If treatment is delayed the appendix may rupture and results in infection of the abdomen, called **peritonitis**.

Hiatus Hernia (Diaphragmatic Hernia)

It is a structural abnormality in which superior part of the stomach protrudes slightly above the diaphragm. The exact cause of hiatus hernias is not known. In some people, injury or other damage may weaken muscle tissue, by applying too much pressure (repeatedly) on the muscles around the stomach while coughing, vomiting, and straining during bowel movement and lifting heavy object. Heart burn is also common in those with a hiatus hernia. In this condition, stomach contents travel back into the oesophagus or even into oral cavity and causes pain in the centre of the chest due to the eroding nature of acidity (Figure.5.10).

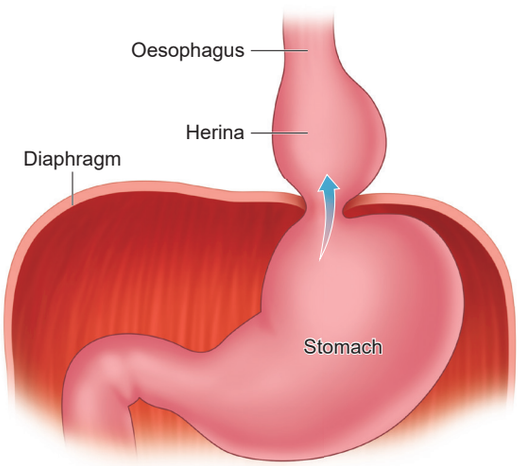


Figure 5.10 Hiatus hernia

Diarrhoea

It is the most common gastrointestinal disorder worldwide. It is sometimes caused by bacteria or viral infections through food or water. When the colon is infected, the lining of the intestine is damaged by the pathogens, thereby the colon is unable to absorb fluid. The abnormal frequency of bowel movement and increased liquidity of the faecal discharge is known as diarrhoea. Unless the condition is treated, dehydration can occur. Treatment is known as **oral hydration therapy**. This involves drinking plenty of fluids – sipping small amounts of water at a time to rehydrate the body.

Peptic Ulcer

It refers to an eroded area of the tissue lining (mucosa) in the stomach or duodenum. Duodenal ulcer occurs in people in the age group of 25 - 45 years. Gastric ulcer is more common in persons above the age of 50 years. Ulcer is mostly due to infections caused by the bacterium ***Helicobacter pylori*.** It may also be caused due to uncontrolled usage of aspirin or certain antiinflammatory drugs. Ulcer may also be caused due to smoking, alcohol, caffeine and psychological stress.

Nobel Prize for the year 2005 was awarded to Robin Warren and Barry Marshall for the discovery of *Helicobacter pylori* which causes peptic ulcer**.**

Obesity

It is caused due to the storage of excess of body fat in adipose tissue. It may induce hypertension, atherosclerotic heart disease and diabetes. Obesity may be genetic or due to excess intake of food, endocrine and metabolic disorders. Degree of obesity is assessed by body mass index (**BMI**). A normal BMI range for adult is 19-25 above 25 is considered as obese. BMI is calculated as body weight in Kg, divided by the square of body height in meters. For example, a 50 Kg person with a height of 160 cms would have a BMI of 19.5.

That is BMI = $50 / (1.6)^2 = 19.5$

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